

CHICAGOANS OF THE YEAR

In ways big and small, these are the people who stood out or made a difference in their respective genres

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Chicago Tribune



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SUNDAY, DECEMBER 21, 2025

BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Protester swept up, facing charges

How a garden store worker became part of 'Broadview Six'

By Tess Kenny
Chicago Tribune

Joselyn Walsh was working from her Pilsen home last month when her phone began to ring. It was a special agent from the FBI, the caller said, and they needed to speak with her.

Unfamiliar with the number, the 31-year-old part-time researcher, part-time garden store worker dismissed the call as spam. But then her cell sounded again. This time, Walsh googled the 10 digits flashing up at her.

Sure enough, it was the FBI headquarters in Chicago. And they had a warrant out for her arrest.

"How is this possible?" Walsh wondered.

Walsh is among six protesters facing federal conspiracy charges in one of the most high-profile cases to emerge from Operation Midway Blitz, the Trump administration's mass deportation mission in Chicago this fall. They are accused of conspiring to forcibly impede a federal immigration agent at a September protest at the U.S. Immigration and Customs Enforcement facility in Broadview.

Charged alongside four Democratic politicians and one political staffer, Walsh is arguably the least known of the group, known as the 'Broadview Six.' She said she doesn't know her co-defendants and still doesn't know why, among the hundreds that went to protest outside of the west suburban processing center during the two-month operation, she's been singled out in federal court.

The case stands to test the impact and bounds of protest in the second Trump adminis-

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BRIAN CASSELLA/TRIBUNE

Saturday night live at Soldier Field

The Bears and Packers renewed their rivalry Saturday with the division lead on the line. **Coverage in Chicago Sports and chicagotribune.com**

FRUGAL FUN: The dual-nation isle of Dutch St. Maarten and French St. Martin entices with rich coastal attractions and Caribbean beaches. **Life+Travel**



U.S. Rep. Jonathan Jackson of Chicago stands outside the U.S. Capitol on March 5 in Washington. **BRIAN CASSELLA/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Political ties come to light

Before joining Congress, Jackson owned a construction company. It got \$750,000 from Pritzker's Rebuild Illinois

By Chuck Neubauer and Sandy Bergo
Chicago Tribune

Before Jonathan Jackson entered Congress in 2023, a construction company he owned received nearly \$750,000 through Gov. JB Pritzker's landmark Rebuild Illinois infrastructure program, even though records show the company had scant experience and initially lacked the certification it needed to acquire state funds as a minority business.

The payments to Jackson's 3 I Roadwork Inc. began in the year after he endorsed

Pritzker's first bid for governor in 2018. That endorsement came months after Pritzker's campaign quietly hired Jackson as a \$13,000-per-month political consultant.

The revelations about the state work and the political connections illustrate closer ties between the two Democrats than previously understood and as they both seek third terms next year — and as Pritzker's name circulates as a potential candidate for president in 2028.

They also offer a rare look at how Jackson earned income in the years leading up to his 2022 run for Congress.

The findings also show how Jackson was helped financially by his longtime business partner, influential city developer Elzie Higginbottom, who led the construction project that benefited from the Rebuild Illinois funding. Higginbottom has been a political supporter of Jackson and backed Pritzker's 2018 campaign.

In May, the Tribune reported Jackson — the third-oldest of five children born to civil rights leader the Rev. Jesse Jackson and his wife — has spent significant federal tax dollars to lease

Turn to *Jackson*, Page 4

Budget passes in historic revolt

Political lines at City Hall redrawn; will Johnson issue veto?

By Alice Yin, Jake Sheridan and A.D. Quig
Chicago Tribune

Aldermen passed the final part of a counterproposal to Mayor Brandon Johnson's 2026 budget on Saturday, in a historic meeting that redraws the political lines at City Hall and further imperils his progressive agenda.

The consequential day was punctuated by hours of floor speeches with the usual finger-pointing and grandstanding between the council's ever-deepening factions, before a final 30-18 vote on the remainder of a \$16.6 billion budget for next year that Johnson has failed to stop. The revenue package of that plan passed in a 29-19 vote a day earlier.

Now, all eyes are on Johnson and whether he will issue a mayoral veto. The mayor addressed the floor before the vote to reflect on the weight of his office, even in "times of great consternation and division," by invoking civil rights leaders such as Dr. Martin Luther King Jr. and connecting their struggles with his attempt to tax the rich.

"I know that losing the battle does not mean that we have lost the war," he said in conclusion. "Though we may not have a majority of the council, we do have the people."

Johnson's speech lasted almost 20 minutes but did not reveal his veto decision beyond declaring his stalled budget proposal's corporate head tax is "a battle that is still not over." Few aldermen applauded while he spoke, as the mayor at times castigated his opponents for

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JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

A dilemma without a clear solution

Twelve years after CPS closed 46 schools, more than two dozen remain vacant. Some have sold, but repurposing them is a challenge. **Chicagoland**, Page 3

THE ECONOMY: The White House tries to respond to economic anxiety gripping both parties that could affect the 2026 elections. **Nation & World**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 32 Low 25

Complete forecast on Opinion, Page 12

\$5.75 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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